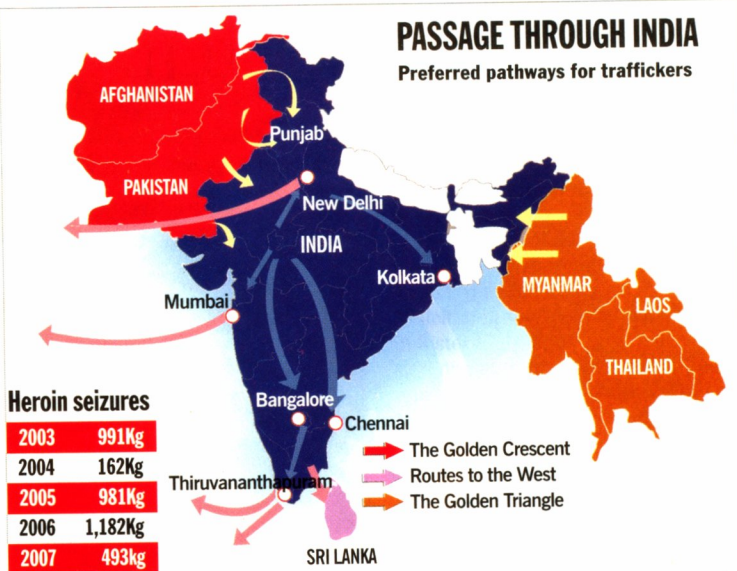




the last assembly elections.

Also, there have been half a dozen instances of police officials facilitating the escape of notorious peddlers from custody in the past one year. Two weeks back, the Tarn Taran district police arrested Sub Inspector Lakhwinder Singh after drug smuggler Resham Singh rattled off the names of police officials assisting his trans-border racket. Recent seizures of heroin were meant for the domestic market while recurring riots in Punjab jails in the last four months were triggered by a crack down on drug supply to jailed traffickers, some of whom are addicts themselves.

Western coastal areas, particularly Kochi, have emerged as major ports for trafficking through shipments, while Amritsar and Delhi are the chosen air routes. Four months ago, the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) seized 11 kg heroin and three kg cocaine while being



IN THE NET: Punjab Police officials with a seized consignment (left); Model Priyanka Das after her arrest

young women as conduits because they pass off without raising suspicion. Model Priyanka Das was arrested from Amritsar last month with a 10-kg consignment of smack—an opium derivative in big demand in Punjab. An alleged operator of a Mumbai-based Nigerian gang, she used to carry heroin consignments from Amritsar to Mumbai and ferry smack from Mumbai to Punjab.

Enforcement agencies find it hard to net the "big fish" running the cross-border narcotic syndicates. "Mostly small-time carriers and peddlers are arrested," adds Saji. But an effective weapon against drug smugglers, who evade arrest due to lack of evidence, is forfeiture of their property under the amended NDPS Act. Last year, property worth Rs 61 crore was forfeited, while similar proposals on 261 smugglers are awaiting clearance from the Centre. "This is the most effective deterrent against the kingpins of organised smuggling," says Punjab DGP N.P.S. Aulakh.

For Punjab, already in the grip of a rampant drug menace, increasing flow of heroin poses another challenge for enforcement agencies. The Government needs to urgently crack down on the politician-police-smuggler nexus to curb a new high in the deadly consignments from Afghanistan. ■

smuggled to Canada in a marble consignment by a Patiala-based dealer.

Smugglers simply toss the heroin over the barbed wire fences into Indian territory which is then picked up by farmers. High profits ensure there is no death of carriers, who earn between Rs 10,000 and Rs 20,000 for ferrying one kg of heroin from Amritsar to Delhi. Not surprisingly, despite arresting 340 peddlers last year, the number of smugglers continues to swell. At present, there are 990 listed smugglers operating from Amritsar, Ferozepur and Gurdaspur. Of these, 91 are classified under category 'A', many of whom have graduated into international drug cartels, while category 'B' has 562 names. So well-entrenched are the traffickers that they control their network from prisons, forcing the authorities to install mobile jammers on jail premises.

Drug syndicates are even roping in